

The Second Larut War Reconsidered: A Frontier Crisis Beyond the Gambling Narrative

A Historical Reconsideration Based on Contemporaneous Colonial Correspondence

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Abstract

This study re-examines the later historical narrative commonly described as the “Second Larut War” using Colonial Office and Straits Settlements correspondence from the mid-1860s.

The records examined for this study describe attacks on mining settlements, burning of houses, organised violence, deaths, refugee movements into Province Wellesley and major disruption to mining and trade within Larut.

The documents also reveal deeper underlying tensions behind the violence. Long before the fighting reached its peak, Larut was already facing commercial rivalry, competing creditor interests, disputes over tin ownership, unstable authority and growing tension within the mining districts.

Later historical narratives commonly associate the conflict with a gambling dispute. However, the Colonial Office correspondence examined during this study instead points toward a mining frontier already strained by commercial rivalry, disputed ownership claims, competing financial interests and unstable authority before large-scale violence erupted in 1865.

Introduction

The Second Larut War is commonly described in later historical writing as a gambling dispute between rival Chinese groups that escalated into violence within the Larut mining districts during 1865. Some later narratives also state that Lew Ah Sam was called in to mediate the dispute before the fighting intensified.¹

The individual commonly referred to in later historical narratives as ‘Lew Ah Sam’ appears under several transliteration variants including ‘Law Sam,’ ‘Lau Sam’ and ‘Low Ah Sam’ in historical and public reference materials.

This study revisits that narrative using Colonial Office and Straits Settlements correspondence contained mainly within CO 273/15 held by The National Archives, Kew, United Kingdom.

The purpose of this study is not to dispute that major violence occurred in Larut during 1865. The surviving records leave little doubt that serious disturbances took place involving attacks on mining settlements, burning of houses, deaths, expulsions and disruption to mining and trade.

However, the Colonial Office correspondence examined during this study does not identify gambling as the direct cause of the disturbances at Klian Poh and Klian Baru. Nor do the records contain evidence that Lew Ah Sam personally mediated the dispute.

Instead, the correspondence points toward a mining frontier already strained by commercial rivalry, competing creditor interests, disputed ownership claims, unstable authority and growing tension within the mining districts before large-scale violence erupted in 1865.

The disturbances appear more closely tied to struggles over mining control and commercial interests than to a simple gambling quarrel.

Sources and Methodology

This study is based primarily on Colonial Office and Straits Settlements correspondence contained within CO 273/15 held by The National Archives, Kew, United Kingdom. The records were accessed through Gale Primary Sources.

The material examined includes official correspondence, petitions, affidavits, commercial claims and supporting schedules relating to disturbances within the Larut mining districts during 1865 and 1866.

This study focuses principally on contemporaneous documentary evidence produced during or shortly after the disturbances themselves. Particular attention has been given to descriptions of violence, commercial disputes, mining finance, seizure of tin, refugee movements and questions of authority within Larut.

The purpose of this study is not to reject later historiography entirely, but to compare later narratives against surviving contemporaneous records presently examined by the author. Where later historical interpretations differ from the surviving Colonial Office correspondence, priority has been given to the contemporaneous material.

Researchers should note that Gale Primary Sources image numbering may differ from original Colonial Office folio numbering or archival pagination.

The Gambling Narrative and Frontier Instability

The contemporaneous correspondence examined during this study does not identify gambling as the direct cause of the disturbances at Klian Poh and Klian Baru.

Most modern summaries describe the “Second Larut War” as a gambling dispute between rival Chinese groups that escalated into violence. Some later narratives also state that Lew Ah Sam was called in to mediate the dispute.

Taken together, the correspondence points toward a mining frontier already under pressure from commercial rivalry, competing creditor interests, disputes over tin ownership and unstable authority before the violence reached its peak.

The Second Larut War therefore appears less as a sudden gambling dispute that unexpectedly escalated into violence, and more as the eruption of tensions already building within an unstable mining frontier shaped by commercial rivalry, competing financial interests, factional conflict and weak political authority.

An Unstable Mining Frontier

The correspondence examined within CO 273/15 suggests that Larut was already unstable before the major clashes of 1865.²

The petitions and correspondence contain repeated complaints involving commercial disputes, seizure of tin, debt recovery problems, disputed ownership claims and accusations against local authorities. Several petitions describe merchants being unable to recover payment for tin already purchased or financed. Other complaints involved confiscation of ore and interference with commercial arrangements.

British correspondence also referred to “disturbances,” “anarchy” and continuing insecurity within Larut.³ In several places, the records suggest that authority within the mining districts was weak, divided or contested.

Much of the mining economy depended upon advances from Penang merchants who supplied rice, provisions and capital in exchange for future tin production.⁴ This created overlapping financial obligations, competing creditor claims and tension over ownership of mining output.

The Fighting at Klian Poh and Klian Baru

The affidavits and petitions leave little doubt that serious violence took place during 1865.

These petitions and affidavits describe attacks on mining settlements at Klian Poh and Klian Baru. Houses were burnt and plundered. Mining establishments were destroyed. Tin and ore were seized. People were killed and large numbers of miners and villagers were forced to flee.⁵

One affidavit described a quarrel between Hwe-Chu and Cheng Siang miners which led to “several conflicts” in which houses were burnt, property was plundered and lives were lost.⁶

The same statement added that a temporary truce and attempted compromise were later arranged between the opposing groups, although the records do not identify any formal mediator or authority responsible for enforcing the arrangement.⁷

The truce did not last. Armed Malays together with Chinese forces allegedly attacked Hwe-Chu settlements at Klian Baru. About 2,000 inhabitants were reportedly expelled after killings, burnings and destruction of property.⁸

Several statements also described refugees fleeing through the jungle toward Province Wellesley in conditions of hunger, exhaustion and injury. Some reportedly died during the journey.⁹

Following the collapse of the truce, the fighting was accompanied by seizure of property, confiscation of tin and displacement of rival groups from mining areas. This strongly suggests that control over mining settlements and tin production formed an important part of the wider struggle.

The violence described above cannot be separated from the commercial disputes and competing financial interests that repeatedly appear throughout the same correspondence.

Mining Wealth and Commercial Control

The correspondence repeatedly returns to disputes involving mining wealth and commercial control.

A large portion of the correspondence involved ownership disputes, seizure of tin, competing creditor claims and recovery of commercial losses.¹⁰ Supporting schedules

attached to petitions listed hundreds of slabs of tin and more than a thousand pikuls of ore allegedly lost during the disturbances.¹¹

Petitions submitted by Oh Wee Kee described how Penang merchants financed mining operations in Larut through advances of rice, provisions and capital.¹² The same records also referred to disputes over who held the “first right” to future tin production.

Several petitions further alleged that tin belonging to merchants or miners was confiscated, diverted or wrongfully appropriated during the disturbances.¹³

Taken together, the records suggest that economic control over mining production formed an important underlying dimension of the conflict.

The Lew Ah Sam Mediation Narrative

Later historical narratives commonly state that Lew Ah Sam was called in to mediate the gambling dispute associated with the “Second Larut War.”

However, the surviving Colonial Office correspondence examined during this study does not contain evidence that Lew Ah Sam personally mediated the dispute.

Chinese-language records, local material or other archival collections may yet reveal additional evidence. Nevertheless, the material examined during this study contains no record of Lew Ah Sam acting as mediator in the disturbances.

Conclusion

The records examined during this study show that serious disturbances took place within Larut during 1865. The violence involved attacks on mining settlements, burning of houses, deaths, refugee movements and disruption to mining and trade.

However, the contemporaneous evidence examined during this study does not identify gambling as the direct cause of the disturbances at Klian Poh and Klian Baru.

Instead, the documents point toward a mining frontier already strained by commercial rivalry, competing financial interests, disputed ownership claims and unstable authority before large-scale violence erupted in 1865.

The Colonial Office correspondence examined during this study also contains no record of Lew Ah Sam acting as mediator in a gambling dispute connected to the outbreak of the disturbances.

Taken together, the surviving records suggest that the Second Larut War emerged from wider struggles over mining control, commercial rivalry and unstable frontier conditions rather than from a simple gambling dispute.

This suggests that later histories of the Larut conflicts may have unintentionally simplified the disturbances by emphasising a gambling dispute, thereby obscuring the wider commercial rivalries, competing financial interests and unstable frontier conditions visible within the contemporaneous correspondence.

Researched and authored by

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End Notes

1. See Khoo Kay Kim, *The Western Malay States 1850–1873: The Effects of Commercial Development on Malay Politics* (Kuala Lumpur: Oxford University Press, 1972), p. 136. The gambling-dispute narrative also appears in later historical overviews and public reference works, including the Wikipedia entry “Second Larut War”: https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?title=Second_Larut_War&oldid=1353989582 (accessed 27 May 2026).
2. British Colonial Office Records, CO 273/15 and related Straits Settlements correspondence, 1865–1866, The National Archives, Kew, United Kingdom, accessed through Gale Primary Sources.
3. CO 273/15, pp. 636, 654, 661. Correspondence referring to disturbances, insecurity and instability within Larut.
4. CO 273/15, pp. 664–665. Statements concerning merchant advances, mining finance and future rights over tin production.
5. CO 273/15, pp. 701–702. Affidavits and petitions concerning attacks on mining settlements at Klian Poh and Klian Baru.
6. CO 273/15, p. 701. Affidavit describing conflicts between Hwe-Chu and Cheng Siang miners involving burning, plundering and deaths.
7. CO 273/15, p. 701. Statement referring to a temporary truce and attempted compromise between opposing groups.
8. CO 273/15, pp. 701–702. Statements alleging attacks upon Hwe-Chu settlements and expulsion of inhabitants from Klian Baru.
9. CO 273/15, p. 702. Statements concerning fugitives fleeing through the jungle toward Province Wellesley following the disturbances.
10. CO 273/15, pp. 637–639; pp. 661–664. Commercial petitions concerning creditor claims, ownership disputes and recovery of losses.
11. CO 273/15, p. 703. Schedules quantifying alleged losses of tin and ore following attacks on mining settlements.
12. CO 273/15, pp. 664–665. Statement of Oh Wee Kee concerning financing arrangements for mining operations in Larut.
13. CO 273/15, pp. 638–640; p. 714. Petitions relating to confiscation, resale, diversion and alleged wrongful appropriation of tin during the Larut disturbances.